

China Internet

Alibaba Group Holding Ltd

Rating

Outperform

Price Target

🔄 BABA

165.00 USD

🔄 9988.HK

161.00 HKD



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Alibaba: From AI reasoning to serving AI work - Apsara thoughts

20GW by 2032. Top down, this year's Apsara felt like a shift in gravity from frontier model announcements to serving infra and enterprise context capture. The number investors likely take away will be 20GW of AI datacentre capacity by 2032 - the first time Alibaba has issued GW-denominated guidance. Assuming 25-30% of capacity reserved for internal use, the company's steer on revenue per GW implies a \$170-180bn revenue target by 2032. Compared with the company's prior \$100bn revenue target by 2030, the new target chiefly extended the runway for high growth, rather than materially raise the nearer-term glide path. In the foreseeable future though we'd expect tightness in the market for compute to make \$12bn of revenue per GW to look overly conservative.

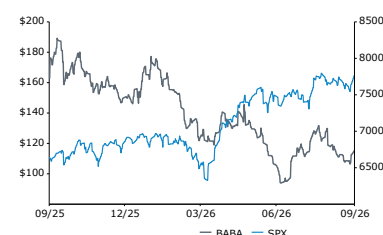
Answering the capex question. Using estimates based on global greenfield norms (e.g. \$30bn of capex/GW) contributes to some very large capex numbers, compared with something like 3-4GW of existing compute today (triangulating 2GW in 2022, and the Alicloud capex ramp in the past couple of years). Speaking around Apsara, management were at pains to stress that its strategy to sell T-head chips to partners - from whom compute is leased back - mean the real capex burden will be lower. The new V900 platform arrives sometime in 2027, and will support a 500k-PPU, 1GW cluster. According to management, strong demand for compute meant contracts under one year were now fully prepaid... which should also help to alleviate some pressure on the company's cash flows.

Compute, context are all you need? This year's Apsara was surprisingly light on flagship model announcements. Qwen4 remains "coming soon". In contrast, the focus was on serving infra and application use cases. Alibaba's analyst day featured an extensive discussion on agentic harnesses... and capture of proprietary enterprise context as the enabler of long-horizon task completion. In contrast with Workbuddy, which has jumped out to an early lead on harness adoption, the pitch for Qoder and Qwen Work centred around distribution leveraging Alicloud scale, capture of proprietary enterprise data, training skills based on collaborative work context, synergies with Alibaba properties like the Qwen family of models, Dingtalk, and smart devices like Quark glasses and smart earpods.

Close Date	21 Sep 2026
BABA Close Price (USD)	115.75
Price Target (USD)	165.00
Upside/(Downside)	43%
52-Week Range	192.67/91.99
SPX	7,764.70
FYE	Mar
Div Yield	0.9%
Market Cap (USD) (M)	287,711
EV (USD) (B)	1,519.33
Performance	YTD 1M 6M 12M
Absolute (%)	(21.0) (3.0) (5.4) (28.9)
SPX (%)	13.4 1.2 19.3 16.5
Relative (%)	(34.5) (4.2) (24.8) (45.4)

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

Price Performance, 1YR



Adjusted EPS	F26A	F27E	F28E	Financials	F26A	F27E	F28E	CAGR	Valuation Metrics	F26A	F27E	F28E
BABA (CNY)	26.82	44.78	64.65	Revenues (M)	1,024*	1,162*	1,320*	13.6%	Adjusted P/E (x)	28.9	17.3	12.0
9988.HK (HKD)	3.69	6.46	9.35	Gross Profit (M)	407,534	378,209	453,261	5.5%	EV/Sales (x)	9.9	8.8	7.7
				Operating Earnings (M)	50,150	98,824	159,019	78.1%	EV/GP (x)	25.0	26.9	22.4
				Net Earnings (M)	64,359	111,480	162,996	59.1%				

*Values shown in billions; Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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A couple things to monitor. Multiplying c. \$30bn of capex/GW by over 2.5-3GW of incremental capacity adds a year would imply over RMB500bn of capex per annum, clearly untenable compared with Alibaba's operating cash flow (RMB200-300bn and rising). Instead, getting to Alibaba's goal of 50% in-house silicon (fab and memory capacity permitting, etc.) - and chiefly deploying the latter via the T-head chip sale/compute lease-back model - looks like a necessary condition for Alicloud to get to 20GW of AI compute capacity by 2032. In our discussions, the company pointed to telecom operators and insurance companies as potential partners willing to be asset-holders in these relationships. In the interim, the fact Alicloud customers are now willing to prepay for compute makes Alibaba's deferred revenue line important to monitor.

The full stack AI pitch. The Alicloud pitch boils down to strategic coverage and synergies across silicon and hyperscale compute driving lower serving costs, a family of rapidly evolving Qwen models (though Qwen4 remains a critical proof point to watch), and a harness and application layer presence backed by Alicloud go-to-market scale. Tightness in the market for compute means line of sight exists between incremental capex (and deals done to lease compute from T-head operators) and incremental Alicloud revenue and profit... which we expect to continue to exceed estimates. Consumption growth in China remains anaemic, which puts obvious pressure on Taobao and Tmall. On the flip side it's probably not that hard to argue Alicloud is valued at a fairly modest valuation, even if one only ascribes perfunctory value to e-commerce.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We rate Alibaba Outperform (PT US\$165/HK\$161).

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

			21 Sep 2026		TTM	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
			Closing	Price	Rel.							
Ticker	Rating	Cur	Price	Target	Perf.	Cur	2026A	2027E	2028E	2026A	2027E	2028E
BABA (Alibaba)	O	USD	115.75	165.00	(45.4)%	CNY	26.82	44.78	64.65	28.9	17.3	12.0
9988.HK (Alibaba)	O	HKD	112.60	161.00	(54.8)%	HKD	8.82	3.69	6.46	10.9	26.1	14.9
SPX			7,764.70									
ASIAX			1,983.89									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

9988.HK base year is 2025;

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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VALUATION METHODOLOGY**Alibaba Group Holding Ltd**

We value Alibaba at US\$165/HK\$161 per share, based on our SOTP valuation for FY+1 revenues and profits in its core e-commerce and Cloud businesses.

RISKS**Alibaba Group Holding Ltd**

The main downside risks associated with our price target for Alibaba include macroeconomic risks (e.g. credit, retail consumption), fluctuations in user engagement with Taobao, Tmall, and other platforms, competition with rival internet platforms, regulatory risks – for example related to China's anti-monopoly regulations, and losses in the company's innovation initiatives & others segment.

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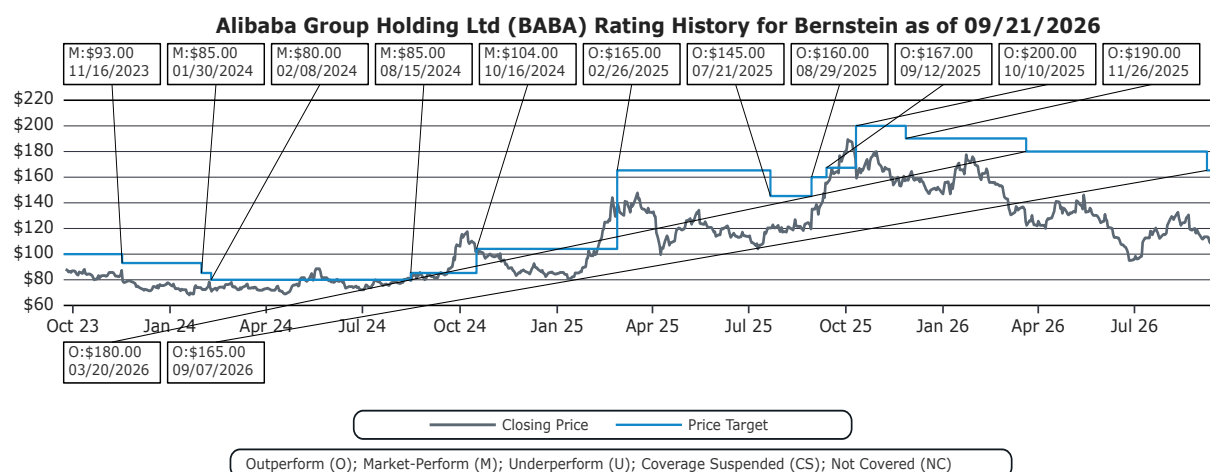
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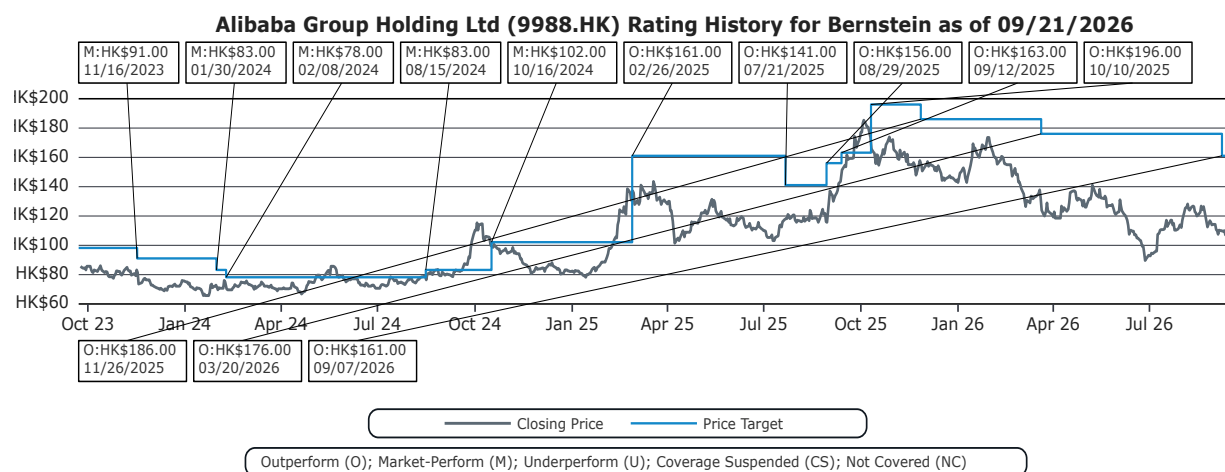
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Market-Perform (Bernstein Brand) Neutral (Autonomous Brand)	HOLD	35.8%	16.2%
Underperform	SELL	13.1%	13.6%

* These figures represent the percentage of companies within each equity rating category for which affiliates of Bernstein have provided investment banking services within the previous 12 months.
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